***Board 1***
South Deals
None Vul

♠ K 8 7
♥ A 10 6
♦ Q 9 7 4
♣ J 10 8

♠ J 9 6 2
♥ J 9 5 3
♦ 5 2
♣ 4 3 2

♠ 10 4 3
♥ K Q 8 7 2
♦ J
♣ 9 7 6 5

♠ A Q 5
♥ 4
♦ A K 10 8 6 3
♣ A K Q

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 2♣ |
| Pass | 2NT | Pass | 3♦ |
| Pass | 4♦ | Pass | 4NT[1] |
| Pass | 5♣[2] | Pass | 5♥ |
| Pass | 5♠ | Pass | 7NT |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

7NT by North
Lead: ♥K

Your 2NT response shows 8+ points, with no 5-card biddable suit.

You support the ♦s and partner bids 4NT. What is your next bid?

With ♦s as trump you have 1 Key-Card, the ♥A. You answer 5♣ and partner bids 5♥. What is your bid?

This is the Queen Ask, wanting to know if you hold the ♦Q. Since you do have it you should bid a suit in which you hold a King. So you bid 5♠. That spurred partner on - he was fishing for 7♦ but when you told him you had the ♦Q, ♥A and ♠K he was able to bid 7NT.

***Board 2***
West Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ Q 8<br>♥ A J 9 7<br>♦ K Q J<br>♣ A K Q 6 | |
| ♠ 10 9 7 4 3<br>♥ 4<br>♦ 10 9 6 2<br>♣ 9 4 3 | | ♠ A K J 6 5 2<br>♥ 5<br>♦ A 8 7 4<br>♣ 7 5 |
| | ♠ —<br>♥ K Q 10 8 6 3 2<br>♦ 5 3<br>♣ J 10 8 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 2♣ | Pass | 2♥ |
| Pass | 3♥ | Pass | 3♠ |
| Pass | 4NT | Pass | 6♥ |
| All Pass | | | |

6♥ by South
Lead: ♦10

Partner's 2♥ is a positive response, 8+ points with a 5+ card suit.

Even though it is tempting, bidding RKCB now would be a mistake because of your doubleton ♠ loser. Instead just support the ♥s. Partner cannot pass, you both know you are forced to game. In fact, partner bids 3♠.

Partner promises first round ♠ control so NOW you can bid RCKB. When you bid 4NT partner answers 6♥. This shows 1 Key-Card and a void in a suit higher than ♥s. Knowing you are missing either the ♦A or ♥K you pass.

***Board 3***
North Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A Q J 8 5 4 3<br>♥ 7<br>♦ A K 4<br>♣ A K | |
| ♠ 9<br>♥ J 10 9 2<br>♦ 10 9 6<br>♣ 10 9 7 5 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 6<br>♥ Q 4 3<br>♦ Q J 7 5 2<br>♣ Q J 8 3 |
| | ♠ K 10 7 2<br>♥ A K 8 6 5<br>♦ 8 3<br>♣ 6 4 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 2♣ | Pass | 2♥ |
| Pass | 2♠ | Pass | 3♠ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♥[2] |
| Pass | 5NT[3] | Pass | 6♦ |
| Pass | 7NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen
3. asks for kings

7NT by North
Lead: ♦5

Your 2♥ response shows 8+ points, with at least 5 ♥s.

Your hand is looking better and better. You already gave a positive response so you know you are forced to game. It is better to keep the bidding low to allow more investigating room so you bid 3♠. Partner bids 4NT. What is your response?

With ♠s agreed as trumps you have two Key-Cards, the ♠K and the ♥A. With no trump Queen you respond 5♥. Partner now says 5NT. What do you reply?

Partner is asking for Kings and you have just 1, the ♥K. Remember, the ♠K is not a King, it is a Key-Card which you have already counted. So you bid 6♦. Partner counts 13 tricks and bids 7NT.

***Board 4***
East Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 7 3
♥ A 8
♦ 10 8 6 4
♣ K J 5

♠ 10
♥ 10 7 5 3
♦ 9 5 3
♣ A Q 10 7 6

♠ 8 2
♥ J 9 4 2
♦ A 7
♣ 9 8 4 3 2

♠ A K 9 6 5 4
♥ K Q 6
♦ K Q J 2
♣ —

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | Pass | 1♠ |
| Pass | 3♠ | Pass | 4♣ |
| Pass | 4♥ | Pass | 6♠ |
| All Pass | | | |

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦3

Partner's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points and good ♠ support.

What you DO NOT say next is 4NT. If partner answered 1 Key-Card you would not know what to do. If he has a red Ace you can make slam, but if his one Key-Card were the ♣A you couldn't. Instead you make a control-showing bid of 4♣, promising first round control. Partner obliges you by bidding 4♥. What is your next bid?

Partner's bidding is like the Sherlock Holmes tale Silver Blaze, about the dog that didn't bark. Partner's ♥ bid shows that he **DOES** have the ♥A, but equally important it shows that he **DOES NOT** have the ♦A. So you know you don't have a ♥ loser but do have a ♦ loser. You bid 6♠.